一颗棉花糖的真相

The Truth About One Marshmallow



一颗棉花糖能预测孩子的未来吗？

英文原文

Picture a **nursery school** on **Stanford**'s **campus** in the late 1960s and early 1970s. A child of about four or five sits **in solitude** before one treat, facing a **blunt bargain**: eat it now, or **resist temptation** for about 15 minutes and **earn** two. **Impulsive** children often **surrender instantly**; **resolute** ones **hold out**.

Follow-ups made the test **legendary**. A 1990 study in Developmental **Psychology** found that, as **adolescents**, longer waiters tended to **attain** higher scores on the SAT, a US **college-entrance exam**. A **trivial snack** became an **emblem** of **virtue**, and **restraint** at four was **glorified** as a **predictor** of **destiny**.

Yet the **foundation** was **precarious**. Only **a few dozen** children entered the SAT analysis, **predominantly** the sons and daughters of Stanford **faculty** and **postgraduate** students. Such a **homogeneous**, **privileged** group could **scarcely** represent **ordinary** families, and **prosperous** homes may **foster** patience and academic success **alike**.

A study published in Psychological Science in May 2018 ran a **conceptual replication**: the same idea, a new sample, **modified** methods. More than 900 **youngsters** from **diverse** backgrounds were **assessed** at four and a half and again at 15. The raw **link** was roughly half as strong as the original finding. **Adjusting for** family background and early **cognitive** ability shrank it by about two thirds, leaving most estimates **statistically insignificant**.

The test is not **worthless**; it may still **reflect** something **substantive**. Research published in Cognition in January 2013 adds **context**: children whose trust an adult had just **betrayed** waited **markedly** less than **peers** dealing with a reliable adult. How long a child **perseveres depends** partly **on** how **trustworthy** the adults around them seem.

中文译文

想象一下一所幼儿园，位于斯坦福大学校园里，时间是20世纪60年代末至70年代初。一个大约四五岁的孩子独自坐在一份零食前，面对一桩直截了当的交易：现在就吃，或者抵挡诱惑约15分钟，就能挣得两份。冲动的孩子往往立刻缴械投降；意志坚定的孩子则坚持抵抗，拒不妥协。

后续研究让这项测验名声大噪（被传为经典）。1990年《发展心理学》上的一项研究发现，到了青少年时期，等得更久的孩子往往在SAT中取得更高分数，（也就是）美国的高考（大学录取考试）。一份微不足道的零食成了美德的象征，而四岁时的克制被美化为命运的预测指标。

然而，这种根据（该研究结论的根基）并不牢靠（站不住脚）。只有几十个孩子进入了SAT分析，主要是斯坦福教师（全体教员）和研究生的子女。如此同质的、优越的群体几乎不能代表普通的家庭，而且富裕的家庭可能既能培养耐心也能促成学业成就（二者兼顾）。

2018年5月发表于《心理科学》的一项研究做了一次概念性的（科研）重复实验：同样的思路，新的样本，调整过的方法。900多名来自多种不同的背景的儿童或青少年在四岁半时接受评估，15岁时再测一次。这个未经加工的关联性，大约只有原来研究结果关联性强度的一半。调整家庭背景和早期认知能力（这些实验变量），缩小了关联性大约三分之二，使得大多数估计值在统计上（完全）微不足道。

这项测验并非毫无价值；它或许仍能反映某些实质性的东西。2013年1月发表于《认知》的研究补充了（一些）背景：刚被成年人辜负信任的孩子，等待的时间明显短于与守信的成年人相处的同龄人。孩子能坚持多久，部分取决于身边的大人看起来有多可信。

词汇与表达

nursery school n.
幼儿园

Stanford n.
斯坦福大学
nursery school on Stanford's campus in the late

campus n.
校园

in solitude n.
独自

blunt adj.
直截了当的

bargain n.
交易

resist v.
抵挡
resist temptation

temptation n.
诱惑
resist temptation for about 15 minutes

earn v.
挣得

Impulsive adj.
冲动的
Impulsive children often surrender

surrender v.
缴械投降
often surrender instantly;

instantly adv.
立刻

resolute adj.
意志坚定的
resolute ones hold out.

hold out phr.
坚持抵抗，拒不妥协
resolute ones hold out.

Follow-ups n.
后续研究

legendary adj.
名声大噪
Follow-ups made the test legendary.

Psychology n.
心理学
in Developmental Psychology found that, as adolescents,

adolescents n.
青少年

attain v.
取得

college-entrance exam n.
高考
on the SAT, a US college-entrance exam.

词汇与表达（续）

trivial adj.
微不足道的

snack n.
零食

emblem n.
象征

virtue n.
美德

restraint n.
克制
restraint at four was glorified

glorified v.
美化
glorified as a predictor of destiny

predictor n.
预测指标
a predictor of destiny.

destiny n.
命运

foundation n.
根据

precarious adj.
并不牢靠
Yet the foundation was precarious.

a few dozen phr.
几十个

predominantly adv.
主要

faculty n.
教师

postgraduate adj.
研究生

homogeneous adj.
同质的
a homogeneous, privileged group

privileged adj.
优越的
a homogeneous, privileged group

scarcely adv.
几乎不

ordinary adj.
普通的

prosperous adj.
富裕的

foster v.
既能培养
foster patience and academic success

alike adv.
二者兼顾

词汇与表达（续）

conceptual adj.
概念性的

replication n.
重复实验
ran a conceptual replication:

modified v.
调整过的

youngsters n.
儿童或青少年

diverse adj.
多种不同的
from diverse backgrounds

assessed v.
评估
were assessed at four and a half

link n.
关联性

Adjusting for v.
调整
Adjusting for family background

cognitive adj.
认知
early cognitive ability

statistically adv.
统计上

insignificant adj.
微不足道
statistically insignificant.

worthless adj.
毫无价值

reflect v.
反映

substantive adj.
实质性的

context n.
背景

betrayed v.
辜负
trust an adult had just betrayed

markedly adv.
明显

peers n.
同龄人

perseveres v.
坚持

depends on v.
取决于

trustworthy adj.
可信
how trustworthy the adults around them

文章简述

- 实验：四五岁孩子面前放一份零食，可以马上吃，也可以独自等约15分钟换两份。研究者记录等待时间，后来再追踪这些孩子。
- 走红：早期追踪发现，等得久的孩子后来在美国大学入学考试SAT中成绩较高，于是这个测试被宣传成未来成功的预测器。
- 局限：早期SAT分析只有数十名孩子，多来自斯坦福大学教职工和研究生家庭。家庭条件可能同时帮助孩子培养耐心、取得好成绩，不能把成绩全归功于自制力。
- 复核：2018年研究追踪900多名不同背景儿童，先发现等待与成绩的关联只有早期的一半；再考虑家庭条件和原有理解、学习能力，关联又减弱约三分之二。结果削弱了原来的推论，却不等于两者毫无关系。
- 信任：2013年实验发现，刚遇到不守信大人的孩子等得更短。等待也受周围环境和成人是否可信影响，不能凭一次测试断定孩子的命运。